Vayishlach 5786

פרשת וישלח (32:4) .וַיִּשְׁלַח יַעֲקֹב מַלְאָכִים לְפָנָיו אֶל עֵשָׂו אָחִיו אַרְצָה שֵׂעִיר שְׂדֵה אֱדוֹם. Rashi says מלאכים ממש, that יעקב was on such a level of accomplishment that he was able to utilize מלאכים in his service.

I recently had shoulder surgery for a torn rotator cuff - Baruch Hashem it was successful. I've been getting physical therapy for the last few months from a skillful therapist. He's a traditional Jew, proud of being a Jew, and a great supporter of Israel, but is basically non-observant. As we were having our typical chat during my physical therapy session, I asked him when was the last time he had put on תפילין. He answered many years ago. I asked him if I brought him my תפילין, would he put them on, and he said yes. To my delight, he put them on when I came the following week. He recalled that the last time he had put on תפילין was with a Lubavitcher chassid somewhere on a street, which prompted me to praise R' Menachem Mendel, the last Lubavitcher Rebbe, for his genius and great accomplishments. I mentioned that there's no city in the world that does not have a Lubavitcher outpost.

As I was speaking to him, I recalled a story that I knew about Dr. Allen Goldstein, ז"ל, a famous doctor in our neighborhood, and how he became one of the world's most prominent ear, nose and throat doctors. He actually was both the Satmar Rebbe's and R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik's ear, nose and throat specialist. When he was a young doctor, he was deciding what to do as a specialty. He was mature enough, even at that young age, to realize that he would need advice as to what he should do with his life, and decided to go to the Lubavitcher Rebbe to ask for guidance. He put on his army uniform (he had been a lieutenant in the Public Health Service), and dressed up as a military officer went down to 770. He said the חסידים took one look at him and thought he was a general, they took him right in to speak to the Rebbe to discuss his plans. He told the Rebbe that he wanted to be a thoracic surgeon, a fulfilling and dramatic position, one that requires a tremendous amount of training, ability and skill. The Rebbe asked him an interesting question. He said to him, "You'd like to help people by operating on their chests. If somebody has an earache and you help them with their earache, is that any different than helping somebody who has a chest problem?" Dr. Goldstein thought about it and came to the conclusion that the Rebbe was right, changed his life course, and became an outstanding ear, nose and throat doctor, known for keeping his office open till the wee hours in the morning with an office jammed with people.

Besides being a genius in learning, a talmid of R' Yoshe Ber, and a colleague R' Menachem Genack of OU fame, Dr. Goldstein was also a master storyteller. When he was sitting שבעה for his mother ע"ה, he was regaling us with stories. One of his stories was about R' Ovadia Yosef. Quite a number of years ago, R' Ovadia's son developed an ear problem. When he sought medical attention, he was told that there was no one in Israel capable of helping him and he should go to America to seek out Dr. Goldstein's care and advice. Dr. Goldstein examined him and determined that he could treat the problem surgically, and arranged to perform the operation. While in surgery, the intercom in the operating room blared out, "Dr. Goldstein, Rabbi Yosef is calling from Israel." Dr. Goldstein responded, "Tell Rabbi Yosef I'm in the middle of surgery and I'll call him back when the surgery is done."

When he completed his work, he called Rav Yosef and told him that the surgery was quite successful, everything was accomplished, and that his son would have a רפואה שלמה. R' Ovadia began to praise him and give him many ברכות to show his הכרת הטוב. He concluded by saying, "In gratitude for your help, I want to give you a special ברכה, I'm going to send down a מלאך from שמים who should stand at your right hand during all of your surgeries." Dr. Goldstein replied, "Excuse me Rabbi, but the Satmar Rebbe already promised me <u>four</u> מלאכים to surround me during surgery." Rav Ovadia immediately responded, "Ah, what are four אשכנזי מלאכים compared to one ספרדי מלאך." We were regaled with laughter, it was so hilarious. So מלאכים ממש are still around, and they still can help us and they still do help us. We ask Hashem for His assistance through מלאכים and through הקדוש ברוך הוא Himself אין עוד מלבדו in all of our efforts and accomplishments, and in that זכות, may all of our efforts be successful.

https://youtu.be/tSZrRZv_QyQ